Setup Zoho Creator and exploring Platform Exploration

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1. Objective & Scope

This document records a hands-on exploration of ***Zoho Creator***, a low-code application development platform. The goal is to understand how an application is built from scratch — from account setup through to a published, working app — and to note the platform's key building blocks: forms, workflows, reports, pages, permissions, and deployment.

Each section below documents one area of the platform: the steps taken to explore it, and a placeholder for a screenshot captured during that step.

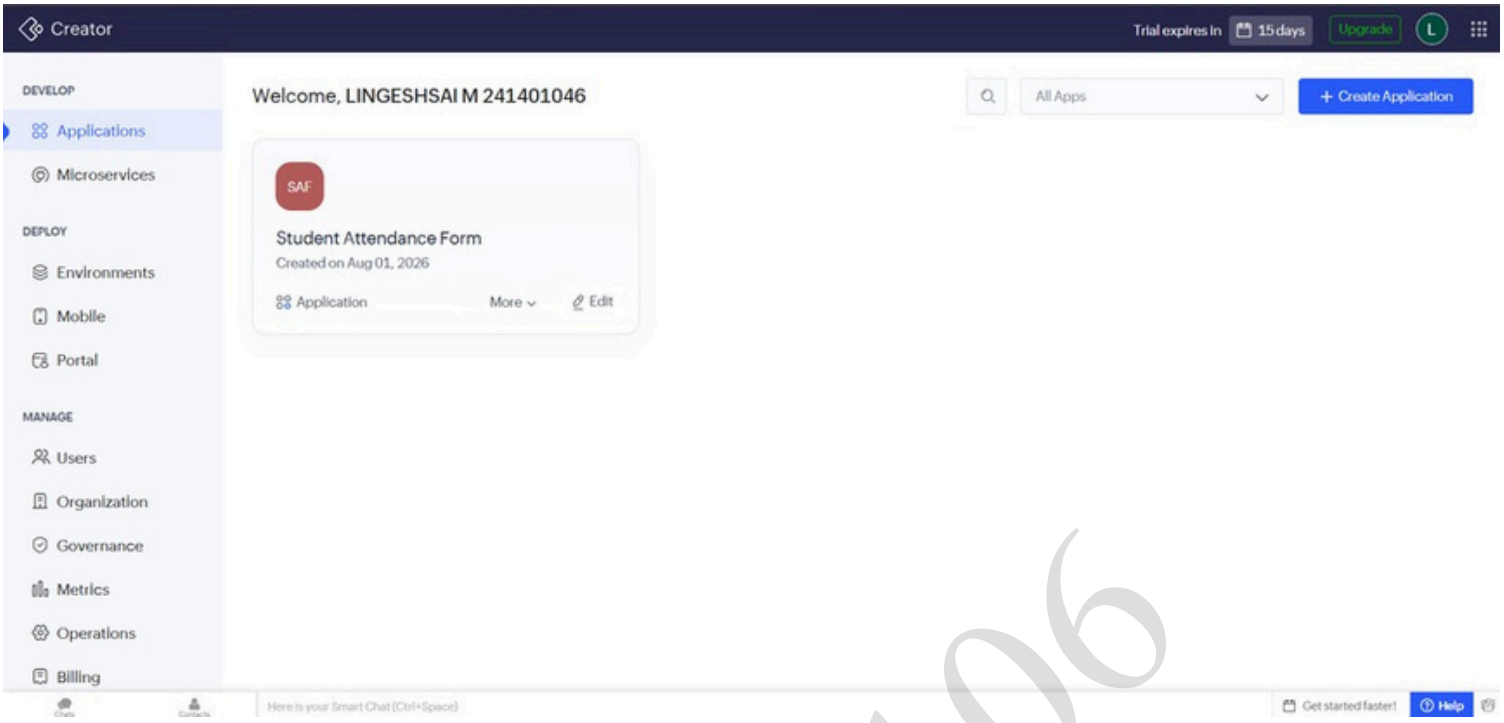
2. Getting Started — Account & Dashboard

The first step was signing in and getting oriented within the Zoho Creator home environment before building anything.

1. Signed in to Zoho Creator using a Zoho account (or created a new trial account at creator.zoho.com).
2. Landed on the Creator dashboard, which lists all existing applications (empty on first login).
3. Reviewed the top navigation — options to create a new application, browse templates, or import an existing app.
4. Noted the workspace/account switcher, used when a user belongs to multiple Zoho organizations.

Observation: The dashboard is intentionally sparse — the platform pushes the user toward either "Create New Application" or a template gallery immediately, rather than requiring any setup first.

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Creator
Trial expires in 15 days
Upgrade
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DEVELOP
Applications
Microservices
DEPLOY
Environments
Mobile
Portal
MANAGE
Users
Organization
Governance
Metrics
Operations
Billing
Welcome, LINGESHSAI M 241401046
All Apps
+ Create Application
SAF
Student Attendance Form
Created on Aug 01, 2026
Application
More
Edit
Here is your Smart Chat (Ctrl+Space)
Get started faster!
Help

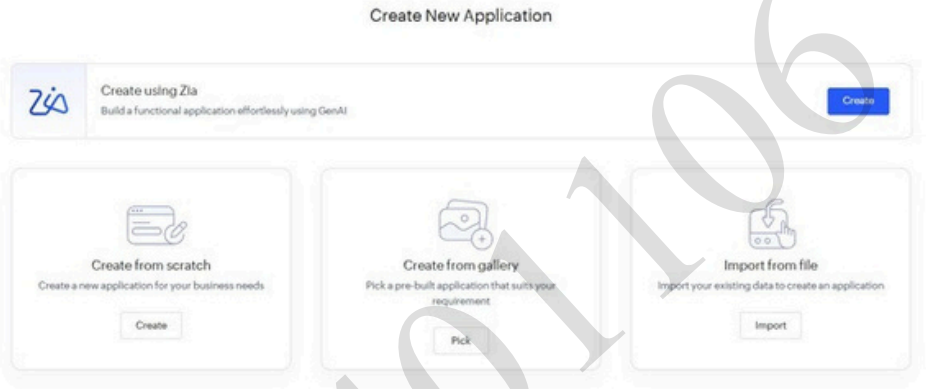
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3. Creating a New Application

This step covered the actual app-creation flow, including the choice between building from scratch versus starting from a template.

1. Clicked “Create New Application” from the dashboard.
2. Chose between: (a) building from scratch, (b) starting from a pre-built template (e.g. CRM, Inventory, Helpdesk), or (c) importing an existing spreadsheet/data source.
3. Named the application and selected the target environment/workspace.
4. Landed inside the application's build environment, showing the empty forms/pages/workflow structure.

> ***Observation: Starting from a template pre-populates forms, fields, and even sample workflows — useful forseeing what a “complete” app looks like before building one from a blank canvas.***



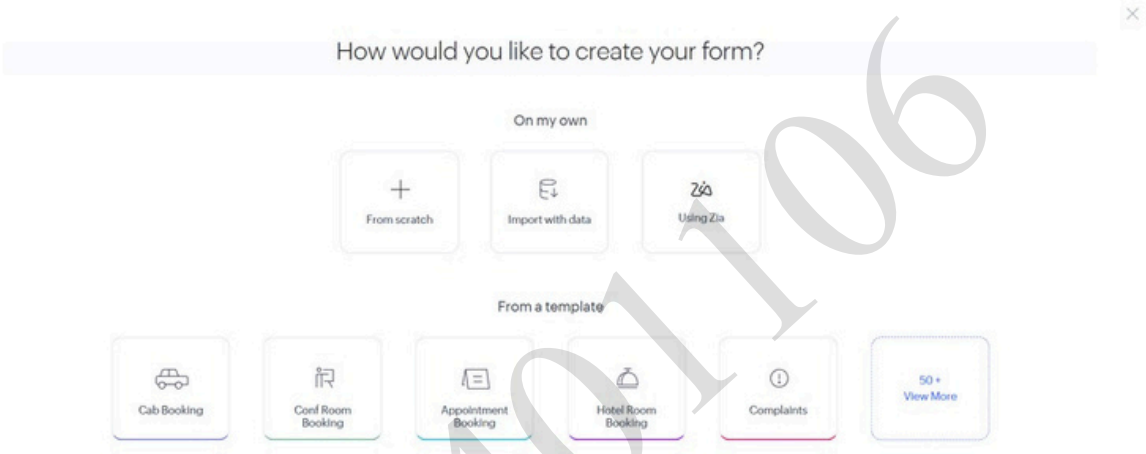
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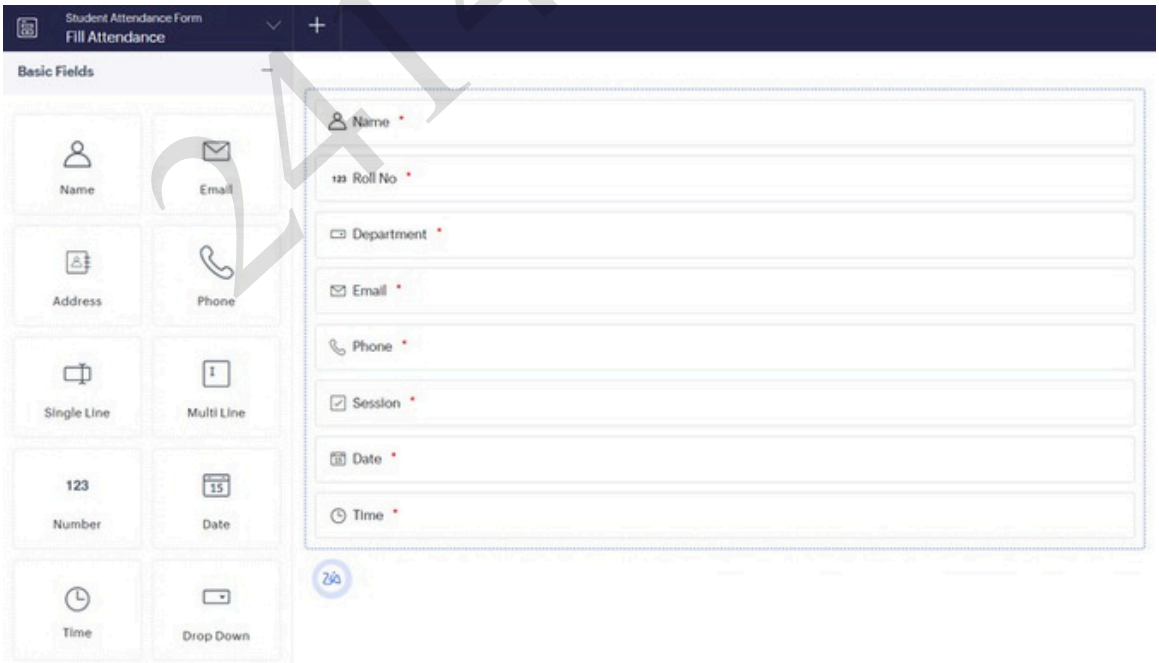
4. Form Builder — Fields & Layout

Forms are the primary data-entry and data-model building block in Zoho Creator. This section covers the drag-and-drop form designer.

1. Opened the Form Builder and created a new form (e.g. “Customer Requests”).
2. Dragged field types from the left-hand panel onto the canvas — single line, dropdown, date, lookup, subform, file upload, etc.
3. Configured field-level properties: validation rules, default values, mandatory/optional status, and visibility conditions.
4. Added a lookup field to link this form's records to another form (relating two data tables).
5. Previewed the form as an end user would see it, and tested a sample submission.

> ***Observation: Field configuration happens through property panels rather than code,but each field still maps to an underlying data column — confirming that the visual layer sits on top of a real schema, not a substitute for one.***





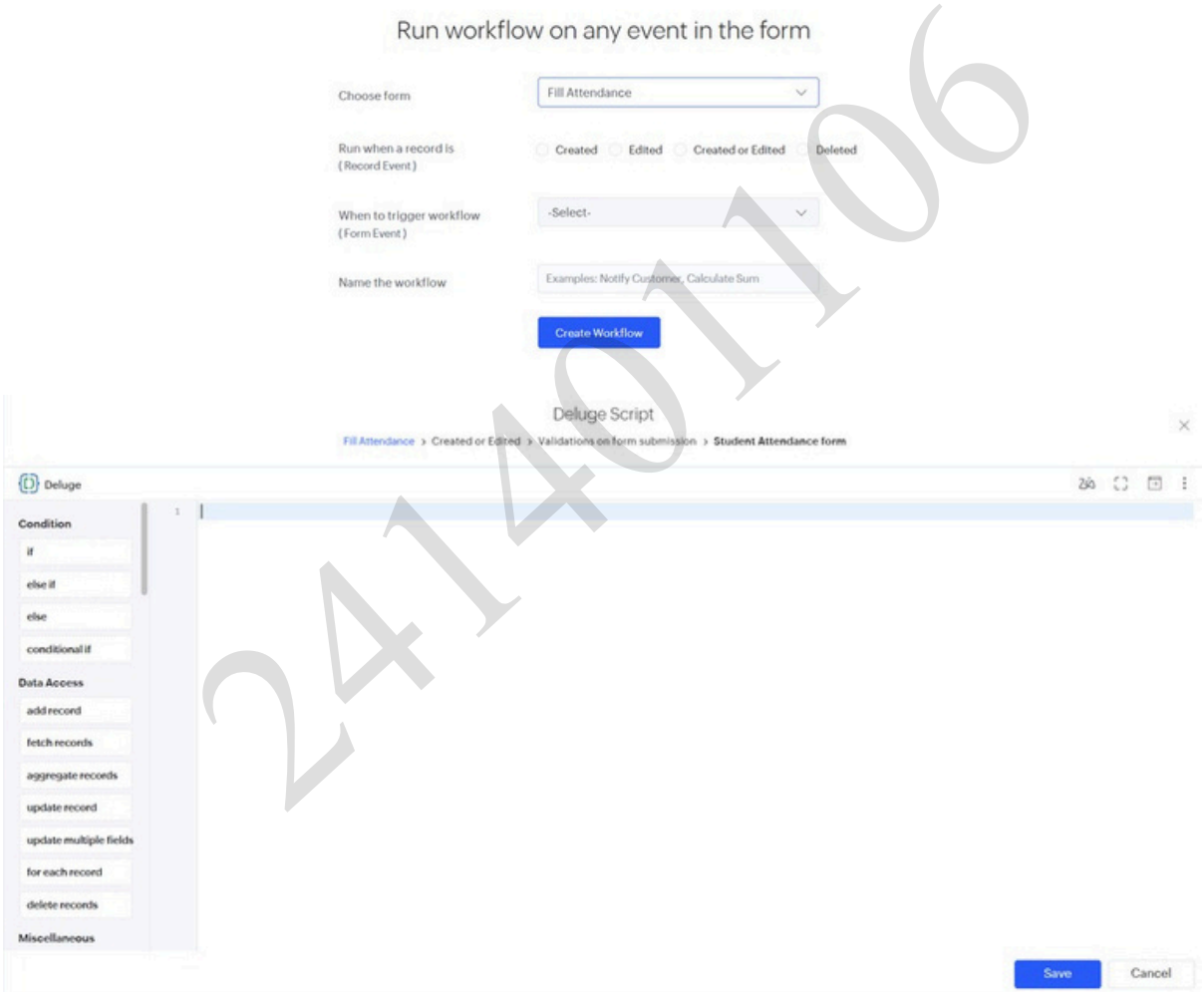
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5. Workflow Automation (Deluge Scripting)

Zoho Creator's automation layer runs on ***Deluge***, its built-in scripting language. This section covers both the no-code workflow triggers and a basic Deluge script.

1. Opened the Workflow section and created a new automation triggered “On Add” (i.e. when a new record is created).
2. Used the no-code action builder to configure a simple action — e.g. sending an email notification when a form is submitted.
3. Opened the Deluge script editor attached to the same trigger and wrote a short script to update a related field automatically.
4. Tested the workflow by submitting a sample record and confirming the automated action fired correctly.

> ***Observation: This is the platform's “trapdoor” in practice: the no-code action builder covers common cases,but Deluge is available the moment logic needs to branch, loop, or call an external API.***



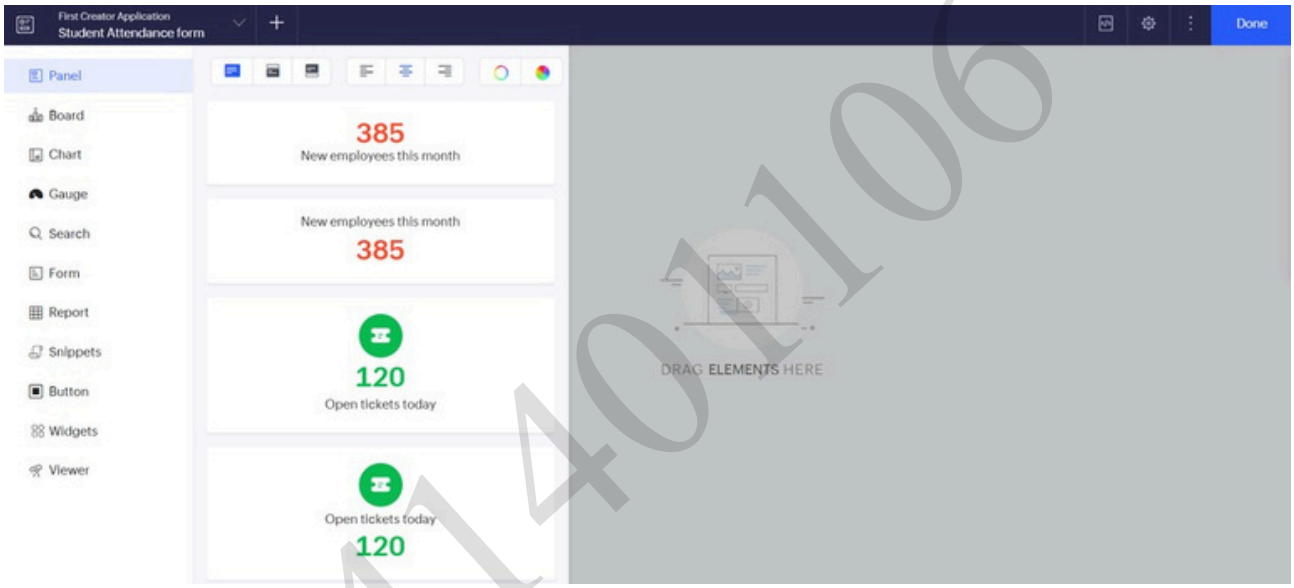
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6. Pages — Custom User Interface

Pages let a builder assemble a custom-designed screen (dashboards, landing screens, custom forms) beyond the default auto-generated form/report layouts.

1. Created a new Page and opened the page designer.
2. Added and arranged widgets — embedded reports, buttons, custom HTML/CSS blocks, and navigation elements.
3. Linked a button's click action to a workflow function (e.g. “Approve Request”) using the built-in action binding.
4. Previewed the page in both desktop and mobile layout modes.

> ***Observation: Pages are where Zoho Creator moves closest to “real” front-end design, but layout is still constrained to the widgets and grid system the platform provides.***



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7. Summary of Findings

Key takeaways from this exploration:

- An application can go from blank to a working, published state without writing traditional code, using forms, workflows, reports, and pages as the core building blocks.
- Deluge scripting is available at nearly every automation point, giving a controlled escape hatch when the no-code tools aren't sufficient.

Overall, Zoho Creator matches the general low-code pattern: a ***metadata-driven build experience*** that compiles down to real, running application logic, with scripting reserved for the cases that fall outside the visual tools' coverage.

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